difficult to cope with all the words of sympathy and reassurance and the looks on people's faces day after day.

While recuperating from the toe injury under the supervision of physio Harshada Rajadhyaksha, who has helped me for over a decade, I had started to mentally prepare myself for the visit of the West Indies. It was important for the team to put the England slump behind us, especially as we had another tough tour of Australia lined up for the end of the year. Preparation was important because the West Indies attack, with Fidel Edwards, Ravi Rampaul, Kemar Roach and Darren Sammy, was not the easiest to face, a fact that became all too clear at Delhi in the first Test, which started on 6 November.

Contrary to the general expectation that we would roll the West Indies over, we were bowled out for 209 in our first innings at Delhi and conceded a lead of 95 to the tourists. Though our bowlers did well to bowl them out for 180 in the second innings, with Ashwin taking six wickets, we were confronted with a tricky chase of 276 to win the game. I went out to bat with our score at 95–2 and was eventually out with just 30 runs needed for victory. I had scored 76 and was delighted to have helped us take a 1–0 lead in the series.

Fans and critics, however, were not quite so pleased. As far as they were concerned, I had fallen twenty-four runs short and the headline was 'Sachin fails again'. The hundred had turned into a fixation and people were starting to calculate my scores backwards from 100. I don't think it had ever happened to a cricketer before and deep down it started to get to me. As the wait continued, a section of the media started making things even more difficult. They suggested that I was only playing to achieve personal milestones. It was a strange paradox. Here I was in Delhi scoring 76 and helping India to victory, yet I was criticized for playing for selfish reasons.

Three Indian batsmen made centuries in our only innings in the second Test at Eden Gardens in Kolkata starting on 14 November, but unfortunately I wasn't one of them. Laxman was unbeaten on 176, while Rahul made 119 and Dhoni 144 in our total of 631. My contribution was only 38. Our bowlers then dismissed the West Indies twice to give us a win by an innings and 15 runs.

The final Test in Mumbai started on 22 November and the West Indies dashed our hopes of a 3–0 whitewash by posting 590 in their first innings, with Darren Bravo making 166 and their first six batsmen all